United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization

Intangible Cultural Heritage

Identification and inventorying

Unit 6 PowerPoint presentation

UNESCO
Intangible Cultural Heritage Section

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In this presentation …

- What the Convention says about identification and inventorying
- Why inventories are needed
- Planning inventorying projects
- Examples of inventorying processes

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Identifying ICH with participation of communities

Article 11(b)

Each State Party shall:
… identify and define the … intangible cultural heritage present in its territory,
with the participation of communities, groups and relevant non-governmental organizations.

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With a view to safeguarding

Article 12.1

To ensure identification
with a view to safeguarding,
each State Party shall draw up,
in a manner geared to its own situation,
one or more inventories
of the intangible cultural heritage present in its territory …

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Why are inventories needed?

- Identifying and defining
- Establishing viability
- Building relationships for safeguarding
- Raising awareness
- Reinforcing sense of identity and continuity of ICH bearers, community building
- Contributing to good governance, sustainable development

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Gender and identification and inventorying

- Important to take into account the gender dynamics of ICH elements in the process of identification and inventorying
- Dialogue and gender awareness within communities
- Marginalised groups and gender bias in identification
- Fully representative involvement in terms of gender in inventorying

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Leeway and restrictions

Leeway

- Adapted to the particular situation of each State

Restrictions

- Identification and definition of the ICH present in a State's territory
- Established with communities, groups, NGOs
- Established with a view to safeguarding
- Respecting customary practices governing access
- Regularly updated
- Reported on

Scope and size of inventories

The Convention does not refer to the preparation of one ‘national’ inventory

The ODs refer to ‘inventories’ within a State, thus indicating that there may be a number of inventories within a single State Party (OD153(a)).

The scope and size of inventories may vary considerably depending on

- the aim
- available resources
- methods of information generation and systematization

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Organizing the information

- It is against the spirit of the Convention to create hierarchies between ICH elements
- To organize the information, some States Parties use the non-exhaustive set of domains (Art. 2.2), often with adaptations and/or additions, while others use alternative classification systems
- Whatever classification system is used, it is important that it facilitates appropriate access to the information by the communities concerned and by the other stakeholders in the process

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Using existing inventories

- Existing registries or lists compiled before State Parties ratified the Convention may be presented to the Committee
- This can, however, cause difficulties as States Parties are expected to indicate how the communities concerned participated in the identification of the information presented, and how they gave their consent for the information to be included
- Older inventories of ICH may require updating not just to include new elements but also to check and, if necessary, adjust existing information
- See also the issue of sustained consent (in EP 4) and the need for regular updating

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Criteria for inclusion

- The criteria for including elements in an inventory should be clear and transparent and in line with the aims of the Convention (i.e. creating dialogue and understanding among communities, and promoting respect for each other's ICH)
- The Convention does not prevent States Parties from using their own definitions of ICH at the national level, for example, in inventorying, but any elements nominated to one of the Convention’s Lists must comply with the Convention’s definition of ICH (ODs 1–2)

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Case study: identifying and safeguarding Estonian handicrafts

What to inventory, what to safeguard?

- Traditional knitted and woven products
- Skills to create traditional products
- Skills to use and develop traditional patterns (even in new products)

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Access to information about the element

Article 13(d)(ii)

… each State Party shall endeavour to:

adopt … measures aimed at: ensuring access to the intangible cultural heritage while respecting customary practices governing access to specific aspects of such heritage.

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Australian Institute of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Studies

- Code of ethics for researchers
- Enforces customary limitations on access to indigenous ICH databases
- Requires users to respect cultural sensitivities
- Protocols allow indigenous control over access to sensitive items

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From inventories to nominations

- Nominated elements to be included in an inventory of the ICH present in the territories of the submitting States Parties (Criteria U.5 and R.5 in ODs 1– 2)
- Proof of inclusion of the element on the inventory required on the forms
- Inventory can be work-in-progress

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Planning an inventorying project: basic tasks

- Determining the purpose of the inventory
- Identifying and involving the communities concerned and other stakeholders (including NGOs)
- Addressing the gender dimension of identifying and inventorying
- Building consultative mechanisms and trust, obtaining consent
- Finding resources
- Identifying/creating structures for information gathering and networking
- Information gathering and data entry
- Dissemination, access and updating

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Planning an inventorying project: many questions

…?; …?;

…?; …?;

…?; …?;

…?; …?;

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Advice on inventorying from UNESCO?

- No specific instructions in Convention or ODs
- No indications from Committee or Secretariat, but:
- On the website of the Convention:
    - Descriptions of inventorying exercises
    - Kit of the Convention
    - Model questionnaire for adaptation (Unit 6 Hand-out)
    - Twelve Ethical Principles

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Examples of inventories

Canada

Uganda

Brazil

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Case study: Newfoundland and Labrador (Canada) inventory

- Inventory-making as part of provincial policies for safeguarding ICH
- Coordinating structures appointed
- Community participation
- Community development as a major purpose
- Cooperation between government, academia, NGOs and communities
- Results available online

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Case study: community-based inventory in Uganda

Busoga community practising their interviewing skills for inventorying the intangible heritage
© Centre for Performing Arts and Culture

- Ministry tasks local NGO
- Twelve Busoga community members trained to identify and inventory ICH elements in their own community
- Questionnaires developed
- Community consulted
- Information gathered will be included in the national ICH inventory for Uganda

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Case study: many inventories and a registry in Brazil

- Institutional and legal infrastructure for ICH research and inventorying since the 1950s
- Numerous inventories on lower level
- A national inventory and a registry
- Strong emphasis on community participation and consent

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Case study: a community-driven inventory in Estonia

- Community members with specialist skills manage inventory project after initial consultations with national working group
- Community organizations and schools get involved
- ICH database managed by a central state agency for ICH

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